

for *Fishhead, How I Saved the World*

Allusions, quotes, in-jokes, and sundry mental rubbish, usually without inline explanation.

To some extent, this is my equivalent of the *Sgt Pepper* album cover. Nevertheless, I probably missed a few from the book. By “after” I mean that the usage is inexact or only based on the original.
“Owner” PW for this and other PDFs is *Stanhope*.

If you managed to open this PDF, please do not share. I intend this information for research only. Thanks.

IN APPROXIMATE ORDER OF APPEARANCE *anachronism; so sue me.

Cover and front matter

front cover—the map is slightly tweaked, particularly with a subtle dot for Kanchanpur. And if you look closely, I added “Bylander” on the boy’s shirt sleeve for my cousin Sue who assisted me with the image. And the two guys lifting the fish net in the pond *I think* are Peter and Donn.

back cover—those were journals I kept at other times, and I added the handwriting, because I didn’t have my original Nepal journals to photo. The aerogramme, too, is a mash-up but using a real logo, stamps, and my handwriting. The sun slowly rises over the Terai!—mock-story opening Peter used to say during early mornings at training. cross-cultural sensitivity training—we used to laugh at the nerdy correctness of this phrase. Nepal’s NW corner with India and China—I made it pointy just because Nepal claims this border shape.

Introduction

in proportion to the advantage—I forget where I got this. Note: The introduction, also the afterword, has many little phrases I liked that I read here and there but no longer remember the source.
throwing people at people to help people—after “people pulling people out of people,” a deliberately touchy-feely joke about midwifery by Hank Habicht (former deputy administrator of EPA).*
time passes—from Karen Burgan, friend, motioning with her hands.*
but we were, each of us, interested—after LOTR movie intro.*
the Ultimate Realities and Infinite Complexities of the Metaphysical Sarga and Empirical Visarga in the Divine Cosmogenic Hiranyagarbha—that’s a real thing; I did not make up those words.
he forgot toilet paper—alluding to those who use water and the left hand instead of toilet paper.
there and back again—from the title of Bilbo’s (fictitious) book in *The Hobbit*.
in nearly every way that a person can grow—after old Rose, from *Titanic*.*
map lines and airplane—after Indy’s flight to Nepal, *Raiders of the Lost Ark*.
company where my father worked—Hague International, of course.
Lodern—Lodern spoke German, so “blaze” after his real middle name. I won’t reveal his full name.
gain experience of the world—after Ulysses (or Odysseus; I forget).
if you ask me—from ersatz movie reviews by Libby Gelman-Waxner aka Paul Rudnick.*
tip-of-the-iceberg—Hemingway’s writing style, or Theory of Omission.
if you take my meaning—something Bilbo said.
didn’t have time to make it short—not sure of source; Jefferson? Twain?
the pen is ruled upon skill—originally “tongue” in “Me Lyketh Ever” song.
or *ama* [mother] instead of *aamaa*—needling Broughton Coburn’s inconsistent transliteration of the vowels in आमा.
more tongue biting—keeping your mouth shut (about politics, or religion, or anything else in Murica).

September 1984

weak tea with cream in it—food of the Bread-and-Butterfly, in (Alice through the) *Looking-Glass*.
eradicate or fix anything—Christopher Dodd in *Towering Task* video.*
the rice is a stage and all the veggies are players—after *As You Like It*.
dusty day; bewildering—after “Kathmandu” by Cat Stevens.
dropping like flies—from *Waiting for The Electrician or Someone Like Him*, Firesign Theater.

October 1984

clouds of flying bobby pins—after the witch in a Bugs Bunny cartoon.
what an adorable creature—from Marion, about a monkey, *Raiders of the Lost Ark*.
it's only a model—from distant scenery in *Monty Python and the Holy Grail*.
something amazing, I guess—from the neighbor boy in *The Incredibles*.
may find myself living in a bamboo room—after “Once in a Lifetime” by The Talking Heads.
it's kind of like cooties—after “Jeanie’s Diner” song, except she says “Bewitched.”
bogartus—negative adjective, from former coworkers at Hague International.
a phantasmal drop— after *Lost Horizon* by William Morrow.
there was music still on MTV—after song “1985.”
no Moxie—the fabled and unsurpassed proto-Coca-Cola found in New England.
Gilbert’s 1757 Feudal Tenures states of sons, “the eldest—yes, that’s a f, a “long s.” Just for fun.
which families each of us would stay with—because some of us Trainees got homestays with families in fancy houses,
and I ended up in a mud hut. Did Steve play favorites with us?
could dig the show—from “Easy Come, Easy Go” sung by Bobby Sherman.

November 1984

a pond owner and his two kids (collage)—a man named Decambar Jha.
I’m a big man so I can wear a big plaid—after the caption of a *New Yorker* comic.
I think they get as frustrated as I am—John Dunbar thoughts, *Dances with Wolves*.
but it breathes like Egyptian cotton—from Edna Mode, *The Incredibles*.
jungle-red (sari)—suggestive nail polish color from *The Women* movie.
it all looks delicious, but I couldn’t eat another bite—from *Bloom County* mocking Nancy Reagan.
Dulle Griet landscape—the “Mad Meg” painting by Pieter Bruegel Elder.
eat in America. And eat. And eat. And eat.—after intro speech but “and wait”; *Casablanca* movie.
make it easy on yourself—after Sally’s letter to Santa (about money), *Charlie Brown Christmas*.
“random” airport screenings—turban wearers get pulled aside by TSA staff lying it’s “at random.”
dashing through the snow—from “Jingle Bells” Christmas song.
What have I done?—from “Once in a Lifetime” by Talking Heads.

December 1984

not “Charlie”—name and photo of my kitty, 1997-2015.* (I miss you, sweetie.)
the crowded bus photo—I inserted my face from the goat beheading photo into the crowd. (“chicken bus” was Ruth Miller, Guatemala RPCV who mentioned it to me.)
and then there were eleven—after Agatha Christie book title.
as a elephant’s you know what—sic, from song in *Oklahoma!*
candiru—legends of wriggling into penises (the fish has backward spines) are unfounded. We hope.
warm face, warm hands, warm feet—from *My Fair Lady*.
ire proof—from the ‘Rage Warehouse in Cambridge, Mass.
hrududil—Lapine for “vehicle,” from *Watership Down* by Richard Adams.
to avoid confusion with pickles—gurkins. Ha.
rattle our fuckin’ jewelry—after non-sanitized version of John Lennon’s joke at the Palladium.
look how much...this culture, they said.—after the old saw, “it’ll be fun, they said.”
the craziest party that could ever be—from “Mama Told Me Not to Come” song by Three Dog Night.
really nice farewell—the original remind was, “you have a really nice wife...” Yes, figure it out.

January 1985

I could see India from it—the closest I dared get to inserting the anachronism of Sarah Palin / Russia.
the Peace Corps Volunteer is [IN]—after Lucy’s 5-cent booth in *Peanuts*.
a nice young man in a clean white coat—after “They’re Coming to Take Me Away” by Napoleon XIV.
icumen in—from Old English poem about spring.
But if I could talk to the fish farmers, learn their languages—from “If I Could Talk” from *Dr. Doolittle*.
last night’s hospitality—after suggestive phrase in *Moby Dick* (but nothing happened).

elementary penguins—from “I Am the Walrus” by the Beatles.
I can’t; I’m waiting for Devesh—after *Waiting for Godot*.
vultures, vultures everywhere—from the pickpocket in *Casablanca*.
crank the volume to eleven—after *Spinal Tap* movie.*
thanks a pants load—Jim Smith (friend) frequent phrase.
clouds are almost in the shape of a camel—after Hamlet mocking Polonius.
to the top of my bent—from Hamlet’s aside about Polonius.
It’s like Thurber—I was thinking of Thurber’s childhood servants, but not a specific one.
these are the good ol’ days—after “Anticipation” by Carly Simon.
Nibble on they tiny drumsticks—after a Kliban comic of a cat singing, “Love to eat them mousies.” In China, I
avoided invoking the Kliban comic of cats in Mao suits saying “mousie dung” about specks on the floor.
if he thinks I’m a waxwork, he ought to pay—after Tweedledum in *Looking-Glass*.

February 1985

So this is Peace Corps, and what have I done?—after “So This Is Christmas” by John Lennon.
fan mail from some flounder—from *Rocky & Bullwinkle*.
how Jesus might look if He was from the Middle East—something I heard a comic say once.
a cheap sort of present—from Alice’s thought, in *Looking-Glass*.
I bought a book in a small town—from Rick, mocking a John Mellencamp song.
when the wind comes sweeping down the rice paddies—after song “Oklahoma!”
the barbed wire image—a photo I took at the Lewis & Clark campground, Slaughter River, MT.
upshot—actual *Jingle Bells* lyric.

March 1985

in a Pato state of mind—after *New York* song by Billy Joel.
also looking for fruit—me, for bananas.
rises up into the sky—from “Flying over London” by Virginia Woolf.
an old man stopped me along the way—after “Africa” by Toto.
who’s on first—from Abbot and Costello gag, “Baseball.”
suddenly, last summer—Elizabeth Taylor movie.
pig butcher and *jar* woman photos—Prada T-shirt and Prada handbag in the back.
waiting for the electrician or someone like him—from the album title by Firesign Theater.
gay with bright red flowers—traditional usage of “gay.”
ice in my cup—after Tom Hanks in *Cast Away* movie.*
I volunteered to be editor—the only editing experience I had was creating the *Tampoon News*, a joke-filled, 10-page
“magazine” I cobbled together a few years before (I had been inspired by *National Lampoon*).
gave the guy a length, then shut him down—after “Little Old Lady from Pasadena” by Jan and Dean.

April 1985

numb nuts—a good ol’ New England insult, to myself.
[fog] blowing in by shreds—no idea where I got this; *Wuthering Heights*?
Hoth snow walkers—after *The Empire Strikes Back*.
or rather, know—from James Thurber’s grandmother, sure of the dangers of driving without gasoline.
great leap forward—Mao’s disastrous policy.
really big disease—from Firesign Theater’s *Electrician*.
in Arabic writing-but whose?—I was too afraid of my own *Charlie Hebdo* to outright suggest that maybe the shoe sole
was a test of tolerance and sanity from Allah.
Giacometti might have been inspired—google an image for “Giacometti dog” and you’ll see it.
jam every other day—after the Red Queen in *Looking-Glass*.
but the levee was dry—from “American Pie” song by Don McLean.
Just another synonym for “grudgingly...,” ya’ll—my allusion alludes to “niggardly” and the DC snowflakes.
helps the medicine go down—from *Mary Poppins*.
wake the wolf—after Lord Chief Justice to Falstaff, *Henry IV, Part 2*.

shade trees for the benefit of all—after Sam Bloch in *Shade*.

May 1985

in desperate need of iced tea—after Nigel on Chanel clothing, *The Devil Wears Prada* (movie).
hippo birdie—after Sandra Boynton birthday card.
five o'clock in the Terai morning—after "Texas Morning" by BW Stevenson.
like a scene in a movie—was thinking of *The Last Picture Show* by Bogdanovich.
the kettle on the boil—after "Uncle Albert / Admiral Halsey" by Paul McCartney.
cool wind in my hair—from "Hotel California" by The Eagles.
I'm afraid Dr. Houston would insist—after Claude Rains in *Casablanca*.
I have, God wot, a large field to—from the "Knight's Tale" by Chaucer.
rice or lentils up before the wind/chaff blown away—after Psalm 35:5.
a cunning linguist—Lodern; but after James Bond to Miss Moneypenny.
a monstrous crow—from *Looking-Glass*.
unpathed waters—from *The Winter's Tale*.
how could anyone ever eat a whole watermelon—after *Peanuts*' Snoopy, reflecting on eskimos.
my own private wilderness—after *My Own Private Idaho* metaphor.*
bacteria are procaryotes—for vegan friends who decided that bacteria are animals, and therefore, alcohol is an animal product.
conflues—I knew wasn't an actual word, *Simpsons* or no.*
tea with jam and bread—after *The Sound of Music*.
they're baaack—from *Poltergeist* movie.
instant ramen counts as "loaves"—if the sardines counted as "fishes," then a Biblical reference.
dawn's early light—from "Star Spangled Banner" (I avoided "dawnzerly").

June 1985

when the wind is blowing—song title by Paul McCartney.
trumped—(MAGA punks, fuck off; thank you, Dead Kennedys).
edibit—a word I made up a couple of years before in my poem "Ecology Primer."
the juices dripping down your face—Rick on mangos, from *Terai Medley*.
My Dinner with Cockroach—after *My Dinner with Andre* movie title.
hot as time; brite and fair—from *The Real Diary of a Real Boy* by Henry A. Chute.
training dogs the mudhouse way—after the marvelous Barbara Woodhouse's 1980 TV show.
brillig—from "Jabberwocky."; a portmanteau meaning 4 p.m., according to Humpty Dumpty.
vexing—from verbiage by Andy Meadow friend.
village smithy—from Longfellow poem title.
all through the night—from song title by Cyndi Lauper.
bed bug battle paddle—after Dr. Seuss verbiage.
Kodak moments—advertising for Kodak products.
as black as a tar barrel—about the monstrous crow, from *Looking-Glass*.
WHAT a good dog—from Barbara Woodhouse, inestimable and sturdy canine trainer of TV-show fame.
if the world weren't split in two—on women's secondary role, after *Calculation of Volume* by Solvej Balle.
has made considerable inroads—from "shall and will," Fowler's Modern English, Second Ed.
Scott Nearing—Maine-based, back-to-the-land DIY guru, it turns out, had interns doing the DIY.
with hey, ho, the wind and the rain—from *King Lear*.
double-bangs mean "all clear," which some haven't realized—I noticed certain male Hill PCVs had no idea how buses worked in Nepal, but they didn't let that stop them from getting it wrong.
I'm a slow study—Perouz, in a Handelsman "Fables" comic.

July 1985

B. Crocker—for Bahia, but later noted for doping brownies she baked, however I seem to recall it was Liz who made the brownies that evening at the (Bonnie Hash) house.
handle your pasta—originally "drugs" in the parting-shot joke by Peter as he left the house with Mark Huis., as they observed the rest of us sprawled, stoned and sick, around the room.

white glove test—metaphor for review of house cleaning.
lemme tell ya, honey—from "Back in the U.S.S.R." by the Beatles.
KCC—Krishna Common Carp was originally "Kommon Karp" for alliteration, but I changed it to avoid "KKK."
reading *Sir Gawain*—this inspired me to start "Baedon of Ang Don," included in my book, *Squidly*.
comfy chairs and soft cushions—after Monty Python's "Spanish Inquisition" skit.
you have to dry clothes while the sun shines—after the proverb about harvesting hay.
a bath and after, the laundry—after *After the Ecstasy, the Laundry* book title by Jack Kornfield*
personal initiative / performance reviews—after certain former coworkers (long after Peace Corps).
he might be 50 and he might be 100—after Thurber's "Mrs. Robinson" (maid; 60 or 100).

August 1985

my Precious—from Gollum, LOTR.
executive directors everywhere—meaning Dwayne, exec director of the Downeast Salmon Federation.
Stookey's henhouse—NEWWORLD studio of Noel Paul S., in an old Maine poultry barn (I visited him once).
impudence and avidity—from *Bartram's Travels*, 1777 (however, about alligators).
where the wild water buffalo roam—after "Home on the Range."
guilty—pun, i.e., a "gilt" is an unbred female pig (she is a "sow" after her first litter).
somehow America will survive—after "Without You" from *My Fair Lady*.
kick up a little dust—from "Midnight at the Oasis" sung by Maria Muldaur.

September 1985

Raiders of the Lost *Charpi*—after Indiana Jones.
in a twinkling—from *Looking-Glass*.
with a path down the middle—after *Monty Python and the Holy Grail*.
undergoing my toilette—after the White Kitten in *Looking-Glass*.
two eyes so, nose in the middle—after HumptyDumpty in *Looking-Glass*.
it's always something—catchphrase of Roseanne Roseannadanna.
Babs Johnson's greatest moment—when Divine eats dog shit in *Pink Flamingos*.
hot hot hot—song title by Buster Poindexter.*

October 1985

it's morning in Dumre—after Reagan's campaign bullshit.
seasons change with the scenery—from "Hazy Shade of Winter" by Simon & Garfunkel.
in blueprint blue—from "Peg" by Steely Dan.
beffas—Dave called breakfast.
with great vigor—from LOTR (book).
we Volunteers must get used...Himals to the Terai—after Major Strasser in *Casablanca*.
it's got a nice beat and you can dance to it—vacuous catchphrase from *American Bandstand*.
my back has been a disaster area—after Dr. Smith on *Lost in Space*.
Merchant Marine friend—Paul Hayward, whose name I (cleverly) wrote in the text as "Hey, would..."
strawberry ice creams-smile—after "Rio" by Duran Duran.

November 1985

places where new things might be found—after "I Just Wasn't Made for These Times" by Brian Wilson.
all those years ago—song title by George Harrison.
The Jewel in the Crown—book title by Paul Scott.
The Empiaaah—my attempt at a Winston Churchill accent.
the town formerly known as Benares—after Prince's name change.*
houses, farms, and fields—from "City of New Orleans" by Arlo Guthrie.
Morrill Worcester—Maine factory owner who puts the Christmas wreaths in Arlington Cemetery every December;
people who live in Harrington, Maine, say he's an arrogant boor.
turned us around like a wheel—I forget where I heard this.
drooling thick white concept—ejaculate, if not already obvious.

just to be there once again—I avoided inserting, “we may never pass this way again,” from Seals and Crofts. (See also the movie, if you can find it, *8 AM: The Moment When Everything Changes*, by Grief Dialogues.)
the night...started kicking in—from “High on You” by Survivor.
transcendental medication—pun on the Maharishi Mahesh Yogi’s thing.
get my slippers—from “It’s Nice to Go Trav’ling” sung by Frank Sinatra.
it’s magic—from “Carrots are Divine” as sung by Bugs Bunny.
foto—from *Roots* by Alex Haley: penis, in Mandinka.
one day more—from song in *Les Misérables*.
the good ones always get it—quote by Lodern, friend.*
chopping some broken wood—after “Kathmandu” by Cat Stevens.
cool, breezy, fresh, air—after *Desert Solitaire* by Edward Abbey.

December 1985

they are a people, not a drink—friend Richard Strange quote.*
WID...a new logo—Anne hit me when I proposed a huge, rounded “W,” like boobs, with “ID” in tiny letters.
as it is—the subtitle of the *Bhagavad Gita*: “As It Is.”
smoldering kerosene combustion heater—after carbon monoxide warnings by EPA, CDC, others.

January 1986

a fact of Kathmandu—after “In the Neolithic Age” by Rudyard Kipling.
now old homes are just money pits—after the trigonometry mnemonic for sine, cosine, and tangent.
harmless drudge—from Samuel Johnson on lexicography.
up on the roof—from song title sung by The Drifters.
write in the shape of a mouse tail—after the mouse’s tale/tail in *Wonderland* (text in the shape of a picture).
dash away all—from “A Visit from St. Nicholas” poem by C. C. Moore.
a few male Volunteers—sorry, I don’t remember names anymore, but I wish I did.
gather at the river—from a Baptist hymn title.
beastie—after Robert Burns poem.
taste takes a holiday—from Mike Shen, friend,* after “Death Takes a Holiday” movie title.
Magical Dysent’ry Tour—after the song title by the Beatles.
I like it fine here—from Sam in *Casablanca*.

February 1986

the *oeuvre* of Edith Massey—pun: she played the Egg Lady (Mama Edie) in *Pink Flamingos* movie.
Wow! wow! wow!—from the pig baby’s song, *Alice’s Adventures in Wonderland*.
if you got kicked out—referring to Paul Theroux, essay author who got kicked out of his Peace Corps country for political activism—exactly what Peace Corps prohibits.
the seductive influence of an old vintage—from *Tarzan of the Apes* (the book, of course).
dawning on me—after song “Aquarius”: “this is the dawning of the age of *aquarium*.”
the answer that satisfied—from a chapter title in *Second Foundation* by Isaac Asimov.
listen very nicely, then—from *My Fair Lady*.
tipple—from verbiage by Andy Meadow, friend.*
long and winding road—from the Beatles song title.
on a clear day you can see forever—Barbra Streisand movie title.

March 1986

slip-sliding—from Paul Simon song title.
a coffee ring on the back cover—*Fishhead* has a trompe l’oeil coffee ring on the back cover.
dreaming a possible dream—after *Man of La Mancha* lyrics.
nothing beside remains—from “Ozymandias” by Shelley.
Michael...met a Fishhead—he’d met Anne, in my group.
here comes the Sen king—after “Sun King” by the Beatles.
men outstanding in their field—after old pun of “out standing in their field.”

the chores! the stores!—from the *Green Acres* TV theme song.

I aks you—sic, after Black coworkers (long after Peace Corps); incredibly, linguist John McWhorter insists the pronunciation is a valid variation (but we can always fall back on confusion between *respect* and *respective*).

April 1986

standardizing words for Brahmin, nose—the original Nepali sign language for “Brahmin” was tapping the nose, because Brahmins are stereotyped with big noses; but the Brahmins overseeing book production overruled it (I

forget what sign they invented and forced the dictionary to use instead) so they wouldn’t be codified as a joke.

my breakfast with Rick—after *My Dinner with Andre* title (of movie that Rick liked).

people come and go so quickly here—from *The Wizard of Oz* movie.

a little mellow hike to the north of Kathmandu—after “Days Like This” by John Lennon, after “Little Yellow God” poem by Bransby Williams.

feeding the worms—after Zhuang Zhou, philosopher, that a sky burial is OK by him.

lustre of midday—from “A Visit from St. Nicholas” poem.

May 1986

embroider on my jeans—after “On the Cover of *Rolling Stone*” by Dr. Hook.

a perfect cut, every time—from a bris skit on SNL, after a car advertisement (involving diamond cutting).

we have become a plural noun—so, sue me.

we are not amused—from Queen Victoria’s supposed quote.

perfectly cromulent—from *The Simpsons*, “Lisa the Iconoclast,” (S7E16).*

carefully taught—from the *South Pacific* song title, about passing racism to the next generation.

trying not to drink it *too* much—somewhat off-point reference of inculcation in Peace Corps & Jim Jones.

praying for a little breeze—from “Lady Godiva” song by Peter and Gordon.

the spirits were about to speak—after *Bullwinkle* quote.

June 1986

boring fuss about—after Marie Antionette’s level of concern for money, from a book by John Canning.

फ्याउरो समाचार; pyauro samachar—Nepali, literally, “fox news.”*

both-sides-now—from a song title by Joni Mitchell.

more paths we could go by, but in the short walk—after “Stairway to Heaven” by Led Zeppelin.

checked our progress; the defile—from *Desert Solitaire* by Edward Abbey.

when the best you can do is waddle—mocking obese gluttons who drive four blocks to a restaurant.

or would you like to plant your own rice?—after “Swing on a Star” sung by Bing Crosby.

crocodiles, Gangetic dolphins, and some working elephants, oh my—after *The Wizard of Oz* chant.

in our sight—after “Late Lament” by the Moody Blues.

drag the dogs everywhere—because I hate it nowadays when people drag their dogs everywhere.

fixing holes where the rain got in—after song title by the Beatles.

muji—means asshole as an insult (and muji.com really is a Japanese retain chain).

seafoam green—phrase by Earl Kavanaugh, friend.*

translations à la Monty Python—First one: “My radish is very long” (radish is a euphemism for penis). Second one: “I like to eat shit.”

don’t fly away fly away—from “Hummingbird” by Seals & Crofts.

July 1986

Barky Lou—the name a friend once gave to a pesky barking dog.

the sun-and-fun capital of—after the Jackie Gleason Show intro.

the trace of *gobar* in the air—after the last song of *My Fair Lady*.

August 1986

I shall now tell you the Tale of the Four Volunteers—after story titles in *The Thousand and One Nights*.

they are cleaning it—from Firesign Theater, *Waiting for the Electrician...*

off-piste—we heard from Jim (B or W) that Darra was cool—they went there—and off-limits to Americans.
I really don't know guns at all—after “Both Sides Now” song by Joni Mitchell.
I didn't write it down—in *my book*. NBC was the network of the reporter we met in Pakistan. But I didn't write down the reporter's name and I don't remember him. Is he well known now?

September 1986

Swept Away—from movie title by Lina Wertmüller.
mad dogs and Fishheads go out in the sun—after the song title by Noël Coward.
Ugh, Serpent!—from the frightened pigeon in *Wonderland*.
there was a tremendous to-do—from “Draft Board Nights” short story by James Thurber.
wanting to join in—I forget where I got this, but it had to do with an open-minded mentality of enjoying other places.
Patan Place—after *Peyton Place* movie title (exteriors filmed in Camden, Maine).
a little Arthur Hailey-esque—I'd read Hailey's *Wheels* a few years before and thought it was dated and simplistic.
That would be something, that really would—from song title by Paul McCartney.
three wise men—from Christmas mythology.
unusually bright star over Janakpur—after the purported guidance of the Three Wise Men.

October 1986

stone temple pilots—from band name led by Scott Weiland.*
out of kilter—phrase my Mom used.
down in the valley—from “You Walk With Me” song from *Big Monty* musical.*
all queens do a walk-about—referring to Director Jim Lehman whom I'm guessing was gay but not certain.
the queen in the Maserati—I kept one joke out of the book: of her shouting, “Will you hurry up! I have TO GO!”
probably never did 185—after “Life's Been Good” song by Joe Walsh.
a monkey wrench—referring to Edward Abbey's other book, obviously.
ABC food—Already Been Chewed, of course. It's true: Indian food is baby mush.
The Manang side of the mountain, on the Chame side of the hill—after “Morning Side of the Mountain” sung by Donny and Marie Osmond.
Khare...on the way to Annapurna—from *Annapurna: A Woman's Place* by Arlene Blum.*
the vanishing sun—from LOTR (book).
out of Africa—from book title by Isak Dinesen.
it's not curious at all—contradicting Dervla Murphy's remark about diglossia in *Full Tilt*.
up to Muktinath where we're going to—after “Kathmandu” song by Bob Seger.
[pilgrimage] it's gained momentum—after R.E.M. song title.
eldritch—from Lovecraft, adjective used in his fiction.
dirty and dusty trails—from “Roam” song by the B-52s.*
a natural exfoliant—from character comments, *Mystery Science Theater 3000*, S4E24.
the very living rock—from *Monty Python and the Holy Grail* movie.
here-come-the ducklings—from book title by Robert McCloskey.
that guy in Bhojpur—Lawton Harrison.
here leisurely warmer—anagram of “Merrill Weyerhaeuser,” scion (was dating Lawton Harrison).

November 1986

divine portfolio—from *Desert Solitaire* by Edward Abbey.
how the *murti* got in their underwear, I'll never know—after Groucho Marx, of course.
wealthy pals without souls—my compromise for not quoting George Harrison's, “the people who gain the world and lose their soul” from “Within You Without You.”
the Scouring of the Terai—after chapter title in LOTR (books).
list of animals—after many of the pieces in *Carnival of the Animals* by Camille Saint-Saëns.
o'er hasty—from Gertrude's marriage as described by Hamlet.
noise in the system—an anonymous, government budget analyst.*

December 1986

the Certificate of Appreciation—corrected version, since someone spelled my name “Jeffery.”
you can take the boy out of the country, but—after the 1960s Salem cigarette ads.
sunrise doesn’t last all day—from “All Things Must Pass” by George Harrison (quoting this didn’t seem to bother me).
my heart beating and my mind topsy-turvy —after “That Pig of a Morin” by Guy de Maupassant.
reclining Buddha—from “One Night in Bangkok” song lyric from *Chess** (or this).
far green country—from Frodo’s dream in LOTR (book).
lotus eaters—from *The Odyssey* by poet Homer.
barefoot boy...tan books—after John Greenleaf Whittier “cheek of tan” poem.
Thirst quenched!—after the White Queen in *Looking-Glass*.
the crack of noon—from old joke about lying a-bed.
a tiny, little, wafer-thin mint—from *The Meaning of Life* by Monty Python.
roast duck—not just duck, so no one thinks we had male prostitutes for dinner.
David Carradine wasn’t just hanging around—read online about his demise, if you forgot.
mama’s little baby loves—a song Lodern sang about congee.

January 1987

perhaps you’ve forgotten my name—from the *Oral English* textbook by Lodern.
midnight train to Chongqing—after “Midnight Train to Georgia” by Gladys Knight.
by any other name would smell as luxe—after “Romeo and Juliet” by Shakespeare.
a slow boat to Shanghai—after an old phrase about China.

February 1987

living in the future—from Greg H assertion that the ability to plan is a personal failure.*
well spotted—from *Harry Potter and the Goblet of Fire* by Rowling.*
hurt something in Shanghai—from a pun of Chinese tones, viz., Shānghǎi in Shànghǎi.
then just walk away—from “Touch Me in the Morning” sung by Diana Ross.
a long time ago but not far away—after opening lines of the original *Star Wars* movie.
though they don’t make the goodbye harder still—after “Oh Very Young” song by Cat Stevens, and also mocking
Anne’s ex-husband Louis Eby who apparently had not heard that still waters run deep.
isn't it pretty to think so—from *The Sun Also Rises* by Ernest Hemmingway.
down to their knees—from S1E1 of *Absolutely Fabulous* TV show; originally “tits~.”
on the waterfront—from movie title starring Marlon Brando.
sensational to read—after Oscar Wilde quote about his diary.
bagpipes—from “My Bunny Lies Over the Sea” Bugs Bunny cartoon.
Cuuuuucamonga—after Warner Brothers cartoon.

March 1987

nothing is real—from “Strawberry Fields Forever” song by the Beatles.
as a parting gift—from common TV game shows.
homeward bound—from title of song by Simon and Garfunkel.

April 1987

letter from a Fishhead—was Brenda Cunningham.

Acknowledgements

not yet!—old Maine joke Rob repeated to me if I, a Mainer, was nearby when anyone said, “all my life”—I was familiar with humorist Marshall Dodge and never said it.

Afterword, Bibliography, and Appendices

Benjamin and the 1992 parade—after another book of mine.*
ignorance is not a more sincere form of knowledge—source?

glass spheres fell off the cliff—after the mechanics of memory depicted in *Inside Out* movie.*

just showing up—after “success” attributed to Woody Allen.

at whiles—from Frodo out walking in LOTR book.

NUI NUI, tiki cocktails—because the *shape* of this text vaguely resembles the “Allah shoe” sole pattern.



NUI?

the lowing of the cattle or the happy summer days—after the ending scene of *Wonderland*.

until old age cured curiosity—I decided not to quote Eowyn in LOTR (book), “To stay behind bars, until use and old age accept them, and all chance of doing great deeds is gone beyond recall or desire.”

brief, shining moments—after *Camelot* musical.

Aphno patti!—“Your own side!” the rickshaw owner in the little cartoon is shouting (journal, February 22, 1985)

re-enactment of a gay RPCV friend—wedding of Tim and Jiwan.

replacement cook—my take on Apple CEO’s lack of vision since Jobs died.*

equally at home in the kitchen or the battlefield—after “~on the carpet or the runway” ad for a 1940s vacuum cleaner.

for my part—from Frodo in LOTR.

Nine-Fingered Mark—after “Nine-Fingered Frodo” in LOTR. Mark Healey lost a finger in a work accident.*

Niger didn’t have a song of her—on unrequited reciprocity, after “Out of Africa” by Isak Dinesen.

funnily enough—from “Harry Potter and the Half-Blood Prince” by JK Rowling.*

beyond my ken—from “Sixteen Going on Seventeen” song in *Sound of Music*.

to change the road you’re on—from “Stairway to Heaven” by Led Zeppelin.

“what’s really going on”—dismissals and eye-rolling by Omar Shafey.

the virtue of stimulating more informed commentary—no idea where I got this, but I loved how it sounded. After I

retired in 2021, I started reading more. I lifted many big words and phrases from articles in *The New Yorker*, *History*

Today, and the New York and London *Reviews of Books*, and many other sources.

busy years may have gone rushing by—after “Those Were the Days” sung by Mary Hopkin.

distant rivers running through it—after *A River Runs Through It* book title.

Majel Barrett—the beloved actress who voiced the computer in every *Star Trek* episode and film to date.

filthy lucre—another Andy Meadowism.*

after which the last Hindu monarchy waned—I forget now, but in some book they referred to this but NOT Nepal, when in fact Nepal was the last Hindu kingdom.

desire need not outlive performance—after *Henry IV, Part 2*.

the interested reader, if there is one—from *Eats Shoot & Leaves* book by Lyne Truss*

“starring”—from typo—I should talk—of “staring” in *Peace Corps Victim* by Patrick Shea.*

petty tyranny—after “Desert Solitaire” by Edward Abbey, about washing machines.

take others by the hand—after “Bodhisattva” song by Steely Dan.

did I say?—I’ve ended *other (my) books* with that phrase.*

the ant image (in the bibliography)—from the Nepali 2nd grade reader (I liked it).

guilty of stylistic irresolution—from *Eats Shoot & Leaves* book by Lyne Truss.*

REFERENCES TO INDIVIDUALS OR SOMETHING MEMORABLE

God’s country—Maine, of course.

joked his standard of living went up—Dwayne Shaw.

je ne give-a-damn pas—mocking Nathan Wilkes, former coworker, who drove that joke into the ground; and who stopped talking so loudly about his high altitude exploits after he learned I went to Everest base camp.

the runs after a couple of spicy kabobs—mocking Karl Schwartz, after he disparaged food at the Kabob Palace.

expect *them* to adapt to *you*—for Bahia Yackzan, not really helping immigrant friends fit in.

came to collect their loved one—for Joel Goldstein’s daughter, who was content to let other people travel to the Caribbean to collect her deceased father’s body.

after being here (I think) three years—mocking Thubten/Jagat, in India for years but never learned the language.

you can’t just sign up—for Thubten/Jagat who adopted the look of Sikh men.

Do my hands smell like fish?—said by a little girl in a restaurant showing her hands to her mother, that my friend

Doug and I witnessed in Virginia in the 1990s and laughed about forever after.

working internally for change—after Lodern’s unforgettable disapproval of my employment choice.

Legend of Virginia—for Dave Gott’s superb brewpub in Richmond, Virginia.

dress like clowns—mocking Wes and others who overshopped for silly clothing in Nepal.

the Adjective Topper / dabble—mocking Christine Dibble, former coworker.

a job in another country for two years—for Samantha York interested in PC but unwilling to actually go anywhere.

be of service in more than just talk—for Samantha York only talked a lot about Peace Corps.
 smarter than me, and know it—for Chris Wrona, whose favorites don't include me.
 "real" Tharus are found only in the Dang Valley—those who talked incessantly about the Tharus in Dang Valley.
 get a better job—mocking cavalier Jody McGowan, my cousin's husband.
 a new burn—mocking Charles Hess, MAGA fool lives in New Bern, NC; can't be bothered to visit his elderly mother.
 movie adaptations of [books]—Aiden Ricci, Carol Flink—insist they know the story from having seen the movie.
 scientific verbiage—for Paul, overwriting his technical papers vs. Karen Burgan, proponent of Plain Language writing.
 tall, blonde woman in my office—mocking Deb Martin, former coworker, very self-assured.
 the angry, perfect teachers—mocking Barb Slaiby and Inge Hindel, Fishheads 1983-85.
 housemate who refused to conserve electricity—my late-80s housemate Frank Leibsly.
 a cunning horticulturalist—Robert Herald, a Palm Springs friend.
 love of all-cotton shirts and hatred of ironing—for Stephanie Cummings' self-inflictions.
 living in the future—mocking G.H. accusation about others able to think ahead.
 director of that Peace Corps office who didn't respond—Andrew Wilson, 2023.
 manager not up to the job of being a manager—I had more than one! Chuck Kent and Jeffrey Levy were but two.
 untraveled skeptic—mocking Andy Meadow who insisted that Chengdu's Chen Mapo Dofu was just another purveyor
 of a well-known dish.
 undiluted—after Queen Elizabeth's "undiluted pleasure" lookback at 1992.
 the job I finally got was at U.S. EPA. I retired in 2021 after 34 years. I did so much web stuff, you can still find my
 name on various things if you google "site:epa.gov jeff morin".
 drowsy sword—Eric Eklund, former coworker, invented this palindrome.
 it was never "Mrs. Ruppe"—mocking Elaine Chao, snooty former director of PC of whom staff said she insisted she
 be called "Mrs. Chao."
 "caramel" has three syllables—friend Jeff Davis's dog's name he pronounced Car'mel—ugh.
 to tell me my fly is unzipped—after *On Writing* by Stephen King.
 The jumble of letters at the end—starting with my first journal entry, copy out the individual bolded letters in each
 journal entry until they run out, re-order them according to the Nepali numbers, then ROT-13 them.
 The Nepali text in the flipping-rickshaw cartoon—see the bold words at Journal, February 22, 1985.
 Mr. Betty (who was all about curry)—my former (and favorite!) boss, Bob Currie: his wife was Betty Currie, Bill
 Clinton's personal secretary; thus in the White House, they affectionately called Bob, "Mr. Betty." (Aside: I asked
 Bob once if he ever told Clinton anything about the environment. He said he didn't think it was right for him to
 speak up directly to the president in that regard; but Bob added that he'd say anything to Gore, the VP.)
 the bug picture in the bibliography—the ant illustration from the "Ant and the Bird" story. I liked it!
 Krishna... obviously not here yet—Bahá'ís told me in 1976 that the next great messiah or avatar was already on Earth,
 but as of 2025, 50 years on: nothing (but isn't it about time; he or she would be getting a bit old for messiah-ing).
 Davenport—Guy Davenport and his essay, "The House that Jack Built" re the (occasionally hilarious) "Letter XXIII"
 of Ruskin's *Fors Clavigera*. (But were Victorian "working men" so well versed in the classics? Or cared?)
 getting mad over this would be a type of attachment—after the *alt text* inside [smbc-comics.com/comic/o-monks](https://www.smbc-comics.com/comic/o-monks)

MORE REAL NAMES OR INFO

Specific quotes (by name):

Anne Bloom: "Losing my wisdom"—my teeth, in introduction.
 Carol Clark: "See some animal sacrifices" (I *did* name her in the text).
 Cathy Marona: drew the map hand, from *Terai Medley*.
 Donn Grinager: "Where can a guy get a... around here?"
 Dwayne Shaw: liked "Chicken Train" song. (You should listen to it.)
 Liz Beck (nee Higginbotham): "like a light bulb" while singing "Rudolph."
 Mark Huisenga: "mind you."
 Omar Shafey: aloof words like "capital investment" (from *Terai Medley*).
 Paul Rawson: "would be well-advised" science overwriting & ignoring plain language.
 Peter Ora: "Esto power!" and Boney M. joke.
 Rick Coffey: "hoo-boy!"
 Rob Giallongo: "here's the tricky part"—the "Big Fig Newton" TV ad with Dom Delouise.
 Tom Green: "winning smile"; "administrivia."

Will Perry: “God’s gentlest creatures” about the yellow hornets.
(Whit Finstrom, Susan Burrill: none—I couldn’t think of any.)

Other mentions:

Thomas Taylor was called "Tourist Taylor" because... *guess*. Also one of those obnoxious male PCVs.
Frank Martin was the PCV building desks AND the most remote PCV ever, a 4-day walk from anything. I don’t know if he reveled joyfully in that or not—Peace Corps Macho.
Ethan, the guy in the *khori* (prison) was George, from Australia.
Lane Smith (wife Chris) was our country director. Their adopted son, Rabi, died at age 15 in an accident.
Neatnik Jim Lehman replaced Lane in mid-1986.
Our doctor was Robin Houston. I don’t know if it was him Carol Clark meant in her testimony, or some overseeing doctor in DC. Robin Houston never seemed to be all that hateful when I knew him but you never know about someone. But also about her testimony in Congress: Carol didn’t say that her parents, once she was back in America, rejected her, essentially blaming her for being raped and aborting the baby and leaving her despairing and alone when she most needed support. Where Carol found the strength or faith to carry on, I’ll never understand.
Our nurses were Bonnie Hash and Corinne Collins. Collins requested the medicinal plants.
Porn Mustache the Dentist was Brian Hollander, DMD.
Steve was Steve LeClerq. Doug was Doug Biggs.
Hiralal’s surname was (is) Chaudhary. Out of respect for their culture, I won’t state Bhauji’s name.
Arun Bahadur’s real name was Manoj Pokhrel. I believe he eventually committed suicide.
Bikram Palden’s real name was Bechan Tamang. His daughters were Sam Maya and Man Maya (the noisy one).
Rajat’s (of the cataracts) real name was Ram Das Raut.
Real names: Whitney Finstrom; Rick Coffey; Will Perry (and the bike guy I learned so much from).
Rick did meet his wife at an RPCV gathering in 1988 or so, that I encouraged him to go to because, “what else have you got to do?” Rick’s wife Nancy died of cancer in 2024.
Fishheads who ET-ed (besides Susan and Carol) are Donn and Omar.
The Peace Corps Trainee who had emergency surgery—Josh Rubenstein’s appendectomy.
Doug Hemken was the Volunteer who needed unexplained gut surgery; also played Renaissance guitar for me.
Volunteer who showed me how to beat my laundry—Lawton Harrison (bf of Merrill W).
It was Rob & Pete who were planning to trek to Rara Lake.
It was Anne who was sick at Bonnie’s and had alphabet soup.
It was Tom and Debbie Fergin who went to Motherfuckapur.
It was Tom at CAST who told me you change, but you change back. Tom was only 3 years older than me, but I looked up to him like a big brother. He eventually married Penny, daughter on an embassy (or USAID?) official.
The three Volunteers in Pakistan going to Tibet—one was Jim Berman or Jim Woodrich (who also broke his fingers in the ceiling fan); I forget the other two.
It was my fellow Fishheads Tom Green, Dwayne Shaw, and Paul Rawson I went to Pakistan with.
The Volunteer looking for windmills was Brenda Cunningham; she has since cut off contact with her cohort.
It was newlyweds Scott Nelson and Mele Smith at Phora Durbar with “I Want You Back.”
Trish Ross was the deaf sign language teacher; one of the kindest, most generous people I ever met.
Barb Minkler was the braille book writer.
Patrick Scannell was the Fishhead we met during training who turned to raising chickens.
Sara McCulloh was the Volunteer whose astonishing language fluency surpassed that of every other Volunteer.
Monty’s (in Shanghai) real name was Ned (I forget his last name).
It was ag worker Sunil (last name?) who momentarily groped me at the Kanchanpur *upkendra*.
It was Greg Barrett who freaked out about being different (blond) in Nepal and dyed his hair jet black and got brown contact lenses. According to Whitney, Barrett once snapped angrily about having his appearance discussed.
I don’t know the names of those alleged Volunteers I heard of that went insane in the Terai.
It was Paul, plus Rob and Pete, who were testing hydrogen peroxide in plastic bags.
Phil Monson and Terri divorced a few years after Peace Corps, though they are still on good terms.
It was Megan O’Donnell with whom I was out drinking at 4am. Megan’s father Kevin was Nixon’s Peace Corps executive director in the early 1970s. It was also Megan who had the house with the view in Bhojpur.
Rich Rosecrance was the Volunteer in Bhojpur whose landlady had been to England.
Loret’s daughter was also named Loret. Loret senior died of cancer in the mid 1990s, Loret junior 10 years later, leaving her husband Peter, also a Nepal RPCV, and their three boys. I tried to make friends with Peter once because we both played guitar, but nothing ever came of my attempts.

It was at Nurse Bonnie's house we had the hash brownies, all the more ironic because her married name was Hash.
It was Indira, peace corps secretary and receptionist, who drove me around looking for my lost passport.
It was Ambika Joshee and I forget who else, who asked me to help with the pension letter to Loret.
It was my fellow Fishhead who Pete died a few years after we COS-ed.
Bill Schaffer was the Nepal Volunteer who in 1984 fell off the trail and died.
It was Joel Heinen who was really drunk (May 1986); but also, when we sat him down on the bed, he slipped out of my hands and slumped backward and hit his head on the concrete wall. I saw him the next day and he was OK but I never told him that it was me who let him slip.
Whit's trekking friend who got a sore knee was Jeanne Rieck and it turned out to be a serious staph infection.
It was Ben Tolles' *dera* that Whit and I stayed at in Marpha.
Liz of my group organized the very first talent show.
Veena Siddhartha danced and Peter Tse played the sitar (and is now, literally, a brain surgeon).
It was Joe Holtrop I met on my way to Darjeeling.
Michael was the name of the Trainee who ET-ed to go home to watch MTV.
Handsome Brit Clive's real name was Paul. Rolf's name was Rolf.
a little awe (in Bangkok) was Jackie Au. She's also the one with the worm that came out her nose.
Krishab's real name Kishore Upadhyay. I changed his name only because I couldn't reach him to ask.
My neighbor, the RPCV from Zaire, was George Orvis; he was killed in a swimming accident a few years later.
The Pato PP was Chandrakant Chaudhary; brother was Devkanth.
Babukaji was Gopal Shrestha, given the "great nickname" of *gobar* by his own staff at the fish farm.
Dina Nath, later Mr. Khan (acting): the real names of the ADOs who kept my HMG rent money.
Sanjay Kumar's real name was Ram Bihadi Yadav (goat herders). In the group photo, he's middle row, far left.
Viyan's real name is Devesh Shrestha; he's the among those who raped Carol.

REAL NAMES INSERTED IN FAKE SITUATIONS

Doug and Eliane—friends who've been to Nepal with me.*
Elvi—my mom. The woman assisting with literacy was Mary, a Brit.
Eddy—my dad. Rick was the real name of the guy with the hot-pad earlobes and big beard.
Charlie—my cat, 1997-2015.*
Shirley and Vera Walsh—real names of my sister, Didi, and her Peace Corps friend, Hadiza (village name).
Shaun at the Hong Kong market—Shaun Ellis, of New Zealand.*
Bruce Khutta—Bruce Foot, originally of Melbourne, old friend from Amsterdam.

NOT ADDRESSED ON PURPOSE

That Lodern had a Chinese fiancée—in case there are political issues with the Chinese government.

Joanna Lumley's role in Gorkha pensions in England—She had the best intentions but it hasn't ended well for some of them, so I decided not to mention her at all.

I didn't include Patrick Shea's angry screed of a book, *Peace Corps Victim*, in the bibliography. I don't mind fair or even extreme criticisms of Peace Corps, but I refused to list this bitter dreck, loaded with exaggerations, disdain, and errors, among the Peace Corps memoirs I read, though I alluded to his writing where I remarked that no one stole anything from the hotel, or refute that "no one" in government cares about taxpayers.

I left off that none of the African countries represented in the First Workshop on Aquaculture, held in Ghana in 1975, mention Peace Corps. I thought that extra accounting would only serve to make Peace Corps look less relevant, as opposed to making Nepal look grateful.

I ignored age-old allegations that Peace Corps Volunteers are secret CIA spies. Nothing I could write would dispel that nonsense and worse, would only make it look as if I were trying to divert attention from "the truth." The most I said in the book about it was, "No one told us Volunteers *this* is how America feels about *that*."

I never brought up much about Nepal politics, royal or HMG. It's important to a lot that was and is going on in Nepal; but I didn't know anything then and now, it's too much digging to work it in either as a faux journal entry or as a footnote, let alone as more than a shallow, passing reference.

I wrote a lot of poetry in my Peace Corps journals but edited them out of *Fishhead* as irrelevant but also somewhat silly (or personal). But they are, unmarked, in the poetry chapter of my book, *Squidly*.; also a long "epic" poem I started to write after I read "Sir Gawain and the Green Knight."

There are one or two brief entries in my journal I wrote using a script I made up in high school. I can't read it anymore.

And in my little screed in the Afterword about American failures & stupidity, I avoided touching on wokeness, as it's actually way too complex to toss around carelessly—that pendulum is swinging wildly. See what I mean: in "Where Wokeness Went Wrong" (*New York Review of Books*, December 2025), Susan Neiman outlines the endless back-and-forthness of its meanings and implications—it's complicated.

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